



# **SYMPTOMS** **LIE**

And in bone stress injuries, they lie most where it  
matters most.



# **PAIN IS A PROTECTION SYSTEM**

It is easy to assume worse pain means a worse injury. In bone stress, that assumption can cost months.

You can carry a serious bone stress injury with very little pain, especially at the highest risk sites. So how much it hurts is a weak guide to how much danger it holds.



# HIGH RISK SITES THAT HIDE

|               |                                                    |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Navicular     | missed for an average of 8.8 months                |
| Anterior shin | classically a mild ache that lets you keep running |
| Femoral neck  | often mistaken for a hip flexor strain             |

# LOWER RISK SITES THAT MASK

## **Posterior shin**

can present as calf tightness, not pain

## **Fibula**

sometimes just swelling or a drop in push off power

When shin pain is actually assessed, a large share turns out to be a bone stress injury, not a muscle (Nussbaum et al 2019).

# SOME BREAK **ALMOST SILENTLY**

Documented anterior tibial stress fractures have had a **negative early MRI**, a real fracture under a scan that looked clean (Smith).

Others stayed symptom light until the bone completed and displaced (Finestone et al 2006). Quiet does not mean safe.



# RISK LIVES IN **TWO PLACES**

Pain is not a proxy for severity. The real risk sits in the injury and the person, not in how loud it feels.

## **THE INJURY**

which site, how it loads, how  
it heals

## **THE PERSON**

training load, energy  
availability, history



# WHY THE SITE **MATTERS**

**4x**

RETURN TO SPORT FAILURE

**3x**

COMPLICATION RATE

High risk sites carry roughly four times the return to sport failure and three times the complications of low risk ones.





**SO I BUILT SOMETHING FOR EXACTLY THIS**

**BIRA**

**BONE INJURY RISK ASSESSMENT**

A free tool that helps you make sense of your symptoms in context, weighing the injury and the person, not just how much it hurts.

Now live.





# **PAIN IS NOT A PROXY FOR SEVERITY**

Understand what is really driving your bone stress risk.

**@stressfracturephysio**

BIRA is free. Link in bio.